

Instant Dice Pools

Not every supporting character needs a fully fleshed out character sheet. Storytellers, if you need to know off the top of your head how many dice to roll for a random character, use the following guidelines: An average person with no training rolls two dice, an average person with average training rolls four dice, a talented or seasoned individual rolls six dice, a dedicated expert rolls eight dice, and a master rolls 10 dice. Add or subtract one die if it's a situation they're very experienced in or mostly unfamiliar with, and there you have it — an instant dice pool. Naturally these numbers can be adjusted, of course, especially for factors such as magic and the like, but on the whole they should allow you to generate supporting character dice pools quickly and fairly for even the most spontaneous and unexpected situations.

The player pauses, thinks for a moment, and says, "He seems like a guy who'd have a cheap apartment, but, like, totally crammed with stuff. Not the best neighborhood, but not terrible, you know?" The Storyteller likes this idea, but adds that it looks like this guy gets a lot of packages in the mail — maybe he's an online shopping addict, or a hoarder. Based on this quick exchange, what could have been an awkward dead end has become an interesting scene; even if the Storyteller doesn't want to work this supporting character into her murder plot, he might turn into an interesting individual to tie into future stories. Or maybe his appearance at the scene wasn't so incidental after all....

Turning questions around in this fashion — or simply opening them up to the group in general, if a single player is stumped — can be a bit daunting at first, especially for groups that are used to a style of gaming where the Storyteller is the only arbiter of game fiction. However, when used well it creates moments of great player/Storyteller collaboration, and can also be a huge help to a Storyteller who's suddenly faced with something "off script" and needs ideas for handling it that will also interest the players.

Share the limelight

This advice applies to players and Storytellers alike. Remember, everyone at the table is there to have fun and tell a story together, and that means giving everyone a chance to shine. Ideally, everyone would get the spotlight at least once per chapter, though depending on the size of the group and the length of a session this may not always be possible. However, a Storyteller is strongly encouraged to take note when a player has been "in the background" a lot lately and see if she can't find a way to move his character more to the forefront for a bit.

It's also important to recognize that players who hog the spotlight rarely do so consciously — most of the time it's not

vanity or selfishness, but just because they are wrapped up in and enjoying the story. So when confronting a player who seems to be taking more than his share of the spotlight, it's best to do so gently, and give him the benefit of the doubt. A light approach usually does a lot more to encourage teamwork.

Handling Problem Behavior

"Problem behavior" describes actions that disrupt the enjoyment of the game for other players, for the Storyteller, or both. There are many varieties of problem behaviors, from heated arguing over rules interpretations to paying more attention to a smartphone than the game session, but the basic approach for handling these actions is simple. The Storyteller should take aside the players involved, let them know what behavior is causing a problem, and see if there's a way to fix that problem and make the game enjoyable for everyone again.

Ideally, such conversations should be done during a break in the session or between chapters, in order to keep tempers cool and make sure nobody feels put on the spot during play, but a player who is being extremely disruptive may require a more immediate intervention. Storytellers should never feel shy about talking to players they feel are causing a problem; chances are, if they've noticed a problem the other players certainly have as well.

Before one comes down too hard, though, it's important to recognize that most players exhibiting problem behavior don't realize it — they're simply playing the game a way they enjoy, without seeing the harm it's causing. Talking to them about the problem is therefore usually better than scolding and punishments, and should be more focused on simply making them understand that their behavior is causing issues and helping figure out ways to improve in the future.

Rules disputes, for example, usually boil down to feelings of fairness, or player frustration after counting on rules working one way only to find that they work another. Inattentiveness can result from players who feel left out of the story and so don't engage in what's going on. Mood breaking, such as players who constantly crack out of character jokes during tense or emotional scenes, can stem from discomfort concerning the material in question. Regardless, it's best to learn the reasons behind it before assuming the worst about a player or his intentions.

It's also worth noting that sometimes even good players — and Storytellers, for that matter — can get caught up in the moment and find powerful in-game emotions spilling over into real-world discussions, such as a player starting an angry argument with the Storyteller over her character's death, or two players fighting out of game because of an in-game disagreement. When such moments arise, it's usually best to call a break and let those involved cool off a bit, while reminding everyone it's just a game and not to take it too seriously. If it becomes a regular problem, it's probably a good idea to sit down and talk to the group about what's going on, and see if there are underlying issues causing these difficulties.

While it's rare, sometimes a player knows exactly what he's doing and actually enjoys making trouble for others. It's unfortunate, but it does happen. This sort of behavior can do serious